

Spain



Lodged between Europe, Africa, the North Atlantic, and the Mediterranean, Spain has occupied a pivotal global position since unification under Ferdinand and Isabella in 1492.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountain ranges in the north, center, and south, with a huge central plateau. Mediterranean lowlands. Verdant valleys in the northwest.



CLIMATE

Maritime in north. Hotter and drier in south. The central plateau has an extreme climate.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A vigorous ethnic regionalism, suppressed under Franco's fascist regime, now flourishes. There are 17 autonomous regions. People remain churchgoing, though Roman Catholic teachings on social issues are often flouted. Spanish women are increasingly emancipated, with strong political representation.



INSIGHT: Over 3000 festivals and feasts take place each year in Spain



THE ECONOMY

Decade of sustained growth, until construction boom ended in 2007, followed by global recession: unemployment soared. Large fishing fleet. Few natural resources. Proximity to Africa makes it a target for would-be economic migrants.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Spain

DATE OF FORMATION: 1492

CAPITAL: Madrid

POPULATION: 44.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 194,896 sq. miles
(504,782 sq. km)

DENSITY: 233 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Catalan*, Galician*, Basque*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 96%, other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Spanish 72%, Catalan 17%, Galician 6%, other 3%, Basque 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents